



Doctors and healthcare workers attend a symposium on Severe Acute Respiratory Syndrome (SARS) in Hong Kong.

“ WE HAVE CONQUERED THE SARS EPIDEMIC IN 2003. ”

Wen Jiabao, Premier of China



Star power

Arnold Schwarzenegger, former movie star, greets supporters during his election campaign for governor of California in the US in 2003.

a series of bloody conflicts throughout the 1990s.

The treaty establishing a Constitution for Europe was approved in June. It aimed to create a consolidated **constitution** for the **European Union (EU)**. It was to replace the existing European Union treaties with a simplified single text, and would

create an EU president and foreign minister.

Arnold Schwarzenegger, a former actor famous for playing the “Terminator” in Hollywood movies, became **governor of California** in October.

Istanbul, Turkey, was rocked by two **bombs** on November 20, which targeted the British consulate and the headquarters of the British-owned HSBC bank. The explosions claimed 60 lives and were linked to **al-Qaeda**.

Iraq’s regime crumbled on March 20 when US-led troops invaded and toppled Saddam Hussein’s government. They argued that Iraq was hiding **weapons of mass destruction (WMD)**. This triggered years of civil conflict in Iraq between rival religious factions. The war was hugely controversial and many questioned its legality. As Western troops began losing their lives, extensive media coverage fanned the flames of public



discontent. **Mass protests** were held all over the world.

Neighboring Iran ended the year with an **earthquake** in the southeast, which devastated the ancient city of **Bam**. On the UNESCO list of World Heritage Sites, the city was more than 2,000 years old. The earthquake killed more than 26,000 people. The US offer of aid helped improve relations between the two nations.

Civil war erupted in the western region of **Darfur**, Sudan, as rebels rose up against the government, claiming the region was being neglected by the authorities in the capital, Khartoum. So far in this civil war, an estimated 200,000 people have died, and 2.5 million have fled to refugee camps.

A virus made headlines around the world and caused considerable panic. **Severe Acute Respiratory**

Fall from grace

A statue of Saddam Hussein in Baghdad, Iraq is toppled from its plinth by Iraqi civilians, aided by US marines.

Syndrome (SARS) is a disease found in humans, which is highly infectious and can be fatal. In 2003, an outbreak spread from China to 37 other countries. Governments took rigorous measures to contain the virus.

Camera phones, which can make calls and take photographs, came into their own this year. They had a profound social impact. Used for surveillance, news gathering, but also enabling voyeurism, they ignited debates about privacy. Some countries banned their use.

2.5 MILLION

THE NUMBER OF PEOPLE WHO FLEW WITH CONCORDE



- April 9 Saddam Hussein's regime collapses in Iraq
- April 14 Human Genome Project to map the human gene completed
- May 12 Huge car bomb explodes in Riyadh, capital city of Saudi Arabia
- April 28 US technology company Apple launches iTunes Music Store
- May 25 Nestor Kirchner becomes president of Argentina defeating Carlos Menem
- June–August 40,000 die across Europe in record-breaking heat wave
- July 5 WHO declares that SARS outbreak is contained
- August 14 Parts of US and parts of Canada suffer major blackout due to power surge
- August 16 Death of former Ugandan dictator Idi Amin (b. 1925)
- September 12 Death of US musician Jonny Cash (b. 1932)
- September 27 US cyclist Lance Armstrong claims 5th Tour de France
- September 10 Anna Lindh, foreign minister of Sweden, fatally stabbed while shopping
- September 28 Power cuts in Italy affect 56 million people
- October 15 China launches first manned space mission; Shenzhou 5
- October 24 Concorde makes last commercial flight
- September 14 In referendum Sweden rejects adopting Euro
- November 17 Arnold Schwarzenegger elected Governor of California
- October 19 Mother Teresa beatified by Pope John Paul II
- December 13 Saddam Hussein captured
- December 22 Earthquake hits San Simeon, California, US
- December 5 Bomb blast on commuter train, Russia
- December 23 Huge earthquake in Iran devastates city of Bam
- November 15 and 20 Two bomb attacks in Istanbul, Turkey